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KCFB KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

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October 2025 Vol. 32 Number 10 kcfb.org

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From Drafts to Decisions: September Brings Hard Lines on Water

TULARE LAKE SUBBASIN SGMA UPDATE

by Julie Martella

Groundwater management in the Tulare Lake Subbasin is now a reality, not just a plan on paper. September marked the turning point when draft language became official policy. Allocations were communicated clearly, and subsidence rules gained teeth. Well registration went from being encouraged to being expected. Conversations about fees are also moving closer to ballots and bills. The State is still hindered by litigation, but the local agencies have not paused. If anything, they pressed harder, knowing that the shape of local control depends on proving they can handle groundwater management themselves. The details may sound dry on the surface, but the choices being made right now will decide how much water can be pumped, what it will cost, and who carries the responsibility when wells run dry.

Mid-Kings River GSA

Community Parcels and Fairness

The Stakeholder Advisory Committee drew a firm line on how parcels tied to community or small water systems will be handled. If a parcel receives water from a city system or a community connection, it will not receive a separate groundwater allocation. This change simplifies accounting and avoids double-counting. Landowners should confirm whether their parcels are classified under community or small system supply, as this will determine allocation status going forward.

Emergency Supply Rules

A new protocol was adopted for emergencies. If a well fails or a conveyance system breaks down, a landowner should contact the GSA to report the source of the new supply. The goal is to assist the impacted landowner while making sure that those providing the emergency supply are not punished with penalty fees.

Cross-Boundary Pumping Rules

Farms that extend across GSA lines can still pump water to irrigate your land, but only within set limits. Transfers of water across GSA boundaries for contiguous farm units were approved, but under strict conditions. Parcels must be adjacent, registered, metered, and part of the same farm. Recharge credits cannot be transferred. This mirrors rules proposed in South Fork Kings and promotes consistency across the basin. At the end of the year, both GSAs will verify and confirm water use. This framework helps prevent overuse and ensures neighboring agencies coordinate effectively.

SGMA Update continued on page 7

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Looking Ahead: The Rain Year 2025–2026

Each October, California's hydrologic calendar resets. For growers in Kings County, the water year, which runs from October 1 through September 30, serves as the benchmark for rainfall, snowpack, reservoir levels, and runoff. This annual cycle shapes decisions across, from planting schedules to irrigation planning to long-term investments in land and water infrastructure.

The 2024–2025 water year ended with statewide precipitation close to average, but regional totals in the southern San Joaquin Valley remained below par. The Tulare Lake hydrologic region finished at 13.15 inches, or 83% of normal, according to https://cww.water.ca.gov/regionscale. These numbers are part of a decade-long trend showing wide swings between wet and dry years in the southern part of the state.

Reservoir conditions reflect that variability. Pine Flat Lake, the primary storage reservoir on the Kings River, currently holds about 227,599 acre-feet of water, roughly 23% of its capacity, according to U.S. Army Corps of Engineers reports. That reserve is more substantial than during the most recent drought lows, but it is far from the flood-control surpluses recorded in wetter years.

Runoff history shows just how volatile the basin can be. In 2017, the Kings River Basin produced 4.1 million acre-feet of runoff, 242% of the long-term average, following a record Sierra Nevada snowpack. By contrast, 2021 saw only 396,000 acre-feet, representing just 23% of the normal amount. Two years later, in 2023, a new record was set, with more than 4.5 million acre-

Rain Year continued on page 8

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KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

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Vision
Ensure that every farmer has the right to farm and protect their heritage

Values
Our Members | Proactive Representative
Reliable | Trusted Resource

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KCFB Executive Director's Report

Dusty Ference

Defending Local Control of Groundwater: Update on KCFB's SGMA Lawsuit

Last September, the Kings County Superior Court granted a preliminary injunction in favor of Kings County Farm Bureau, blocking the State Water Resources Control Board (SWRCB) from charging pumping and well registration fees and from enforcing its interim plan in the Tulare Lake Subbasin while the case proceeds. This was a crucial victory, ensuring that state-imposed mandates do not advance unchecked.

The injunction has resulted in significant savings for local agriculture. Over the past two irrigation seasons, growers have avoided approximately $60 per acre in state-imposed fees. Additionally, the order halted the SWRCB from collecting $300 per well in registration fees. These avoided costs represent a direct benefit of the SGMA Defense Fund and the legal fight KCFB is leading.

The SWRCB has appealed the injunction, and the case is now before the Fifth District Court of Appeal. Oral arguments on the state's appeal took place on October 7, 2025. During the hearing, attorneys for the SWRCB sought to overturn the injunction, while KCFB's legal team defended the trial court's decision. After the arguments, the panel of judges will issue a ruling in the coming months.

It's important to note that this appeal only concerns the preliminary injunction—not the merits of the case itself. Regardless of how the Court of Appeal rules, the broader lawsuit will continue to trial. KCFB remains committed to advancing the case and ensuring that groundwater management decisions remain local.

This battle has statewide implications for agriculture, with Kings County at its heart. Supported strongly by local cities, organizations, and our members, KCFB has made it clear that Sacramento should not set water policy without considering the communities most affected.

JOIN THE FIGHT – SUPPORT THE SGMA DEFENSE FUND

Defending local control of groundwater takes resources. The suggested contribution to the SGMA Defense Fund is $15 per acre, and support from non-farmers is appreciated and encouraged at any amount. Your contributions directly fuel this effort and ensure KCFB can continue protecting the future of farming in Kings County. Every dollar counts—join the fight today.

Perennial Weed Issues in Vineyards

By Joy Hollingsworth, UCCE Table Grape Advisor for Tulare and Kings Counties

Weed control is important in all vineyards because weeds can compete with vines for water, nutrients, and sunlight. This is especially critical in the first three years of vine growth. Weeds can also reduce irrigation efficiency, attract and harbor pests, increase humidity, and create a nuisance for labor operations. Perennial weeds are especially difficult to control because although they may die back during the winter, they can survive and even reproduce through their underground stems (rhizomes).

Some of the most important perennial grass weeds in San Joaquin Valley vineyards are Bermudagrass, Dallisgrass, and Johnsongrass. Bermudagrass forms dense mats with creeping stems (stolons) that root at their joints. It can reproduce by seed, stolons, or underground rhizomes. Disking will expand its population by breaking up and spreading the stolons and rhizomes. Dallisgrass forms loose bunches which are one to five feet tall. It can reproduce by seed and has shallow rhizomes. Johnsongrass is related to sorghum, and its seedlings look similar to corn. It grows in spreading, leafy tufts and sprouts tillers from its base. Johnsongrass is a noxious weed that can reach up to eight feet tall. It reproduces by seed (up to 400 seeds per panicle) and through its rhizomes, which can be extensive. Individual plants can produce 200-300 feet of new rhizome growth.

Other important perennial weeds include silverleaf nightshade, field bindweed, and yellow nutsedge. Silverleaf nightshade is difficult to eradicate once it's established. Mature plants can be one to three feet tall and have many branches. It has silvery green lance-shaped leaves with wavy edges. The flowers are deep violet to blue with yellow centers and produce berries that start green and then turn yellow to brownish orange. Each plant can produce hundreds of berries with 24-250 seeds each. Reproduction can be by seed (which can remain viable in the soil for up to 10 years) or root fragments. They can also produce new plants growing from their extensive lateral roots.

Field bindweed is one of the most problematic agricultural weeds. It is drought tolerant and has very deep roots. Root fragments can regrow after shallow tillage even when the soil is dry. It is climbing and competitive. It looks similar to Annual morning glory, but field bindweed has smaller flowers which are pinkish white while morning glory has larger dark purple, blue, or pink flowers. It is a prolific seed producer (up to 550 seeds per plant) and the seeds can remain viable for up to 60 years.

Yellow nutsedge resembles grass, but sedges have V-shaped rather than flat leaves. It reproduces by tubers or seeds. It can resprout in moist soil that has been shallowly tilled. Dense populations of nutsedge will aggressively compete with other plants and it is difficult to control once established.

See https://ipm.ucanr.edu/PMG/weeds_intro.html for more info about these weeds.

To get more information about table grapes, consider attending the Southern San Joaquin Valley Grape Symposium on Friday, February 6, 2026. Contact joyhollingsworth@ucanr.edu to be added to the grape newsletter/event announcement email list.

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Content for this month's "Ag News in Brief," provided by the California Farm Bureau Federation

AG NEWS IN BRIEF

Public Comment Period Opens on U.S.-Mexico-Canada Agreement

Last month, the Office of the U.S. Trade Representative announced the opening of a formal comment period on the joint review of the U.S.-Mexico-Canada Agreement. Originally negotiated and passed during the first Trump administration, the agreement is scheduled for formal review in July 2026. The process is intended to identify areas for improvement or confirm the agreement's continued acceptability by all parties. The public comment period will remain open for 45 days, closing on Nov. 17. California Farm Bureau members are encouraged to share feedback as we consider issues to highlight.

Farmers grapple with pest challenges due to neglected farmland

Farmers continue to face pest exposure from abandoned or poorly maintained farmland. The sagging farm economy has left many farmers unable to maintain their farmland, with the winegrape sector alone having lost almost 35,000 acres of vineyards during the past year. "There are more and more abandoned fields and orchards," Jenny Holtermann, president of the Kern County Farm Bureau, said in a recent episode of the Voice of California Agriculture podcast, which is produced by the California Farm Bureau. Holtermann spoke with podcast host Gary Sack about the burden of untended lands on neighboring farms. "Whenever there's an abandoned field around you, you have to consider the pests associated with that," Holtermann said. "When you have abandoned fields, our land values are also decreasing."

Pit River Grazing and Forage Exempted from the Irrigated Lands Regulatory Program

On August 22, 2025 the Central Valley Regional Water Quality Control Board approved revisions exempting agricultural operations located in the Pit River Subwatershed from the Irrigated Lands Regulatory Program (ILRP) given their low water quality impacts. The revisions exempt low-threat agricultural operations, such as those growing forage crops, from having to comply with various nitrogen reporting requirements in the ILRP. CAFB submitted written and public comments to the Central Valley Regional Water Board supporting the exemption.

SWRCB Convenes Second Statewide Agricultural Expert Panel

The State Water Board's Second Statewide Agricultural Expert Panel held its first meetings on August 8th and 14th with a focus on nitrates leaching to groundwater from irrigated agriculture. CAFB was represented in two panels raising concerns with the panel's charge questions and nitrogen discharge limits. The panel will meet next on October 1, 2025, from 2-6 p.m. to hear from interested parties and members of the public. The panel will also meet on October 31, 2025, to develop initial recommendations for regulating nitrogen use for irrigated agriculture.

Ninth Circuit Upholds the Clean Water Act's Irrigated Ag Exemption

On September 5, 2025, the Ninth Circuit upheld the dismissal of a lawsuit alleging that the U.S. Bureau of Reclamation and the San Luis & Delta-Mendota Water Authority's operation of the Grassland Bypass Project and the San Luis Drain violated the Clean Water Act (CWA). Environmental groups alleged that the project could not use the CWA's irrigated agricultural exemption from NPDES federal permits because the irrigation return flows mixed with other flows. The Ninth Circuit upheld the irrigated agricultural exemption, clarifying that minor commingling with non-point sources like stormwater runoff, dust, or groundwater seepage does not negate the exemption. CAFB, along with other agricultural groups filed an amicusbrief supporting the U.S. Bureau of Reclamation, San Luis & Delta-Mendota Water Authority, and Grassland Water District, pointing out that the lawsuit conflicts with the Congressional intent of the CWA and threatened irrigated agriculture in the West. CAFB Legal has been following this case since 2011.

AGRICULTURAL RATE DESIGN SETTLEMENT FILED IN EDISON GRC PHASE 2

On August 19, 2025, a settlement agreement was filed in the Southern California Edison (Edison) General Rate Case (GRC) Phase 2 proceeding regarding agricultural and pumping rate design. CAFB was able to negotiate a favorable outcome on the customer charges which will remain fixed throughout the GRC period and limit demand charges increases with any shortfall being recovered in energy charges. CAFB was also able to secure a new pump testing credit to limit or avoid demand charges in the winter months after receiving feedback from Ventura County Farm Bureau. The program highlights include:

- The program would run from December 1st through February 28th
- Eligibility for the credit program will be limited to TOU-PA-2 customers whose NAICS code begins with 1113 (Fruit and Tree Nut Farming) and operates below a load factor threshold of 2% in any given billing cycle within the December through February test period.
- Eligible testing hours will be limited to a two-hour window between 10:00 AM and Noon (PST).
- Qualifying customers will receive a credit applied to the applicable billing cycle, which will directly offset the demand charges stemming from peak demand that occur within the two-hour test window.
- One "freebie" for a pump test that occurs outside the 10:00 AM and Noon test period.

This works out to roughly 11 hours of usage within that 10:00 AM to Noon test period per billing cycle. Edison has also committed to working with CAFB to review and fine tune the program and look at expansion.

USDA fields questions about plan to slash staff, facilities

As the U.S. Department of Agriculture moves forward with its reorganization, questions remain about how the changes will affect farmers. USDA Deputy Secretary Stephen Vaden responded to concerns and fielded questions late last month about the reorganization during a hearing of the U.S. Senate Committee on Agriculture, Nutrition and Forestry. Sen. Adam Schiff, D-Calif., a member of the committee, asked why a USDA hub was not placed in California, the No. 1 agriculture-producing state. In response, Vaden said the proposed hub in Utah is closer to California than Washington, D.C., and said that hub locations were chosen to lower the cost of living for federal employees. Agricultural stakeholders have until Aug. 26 to weigh in on USDA's sweeping reorganization plan, which Agriculture Secretary Brooke Rollins announced late last month.

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SGMA DEFENSE FUND

Join the Fight!

THIS EFFORT HAS SAVED GROWERS IN THE TULARE LAKE SUBBASIN $40-$60/ACRE AND $300/WELL SINCE KCFB WAS ISSUED A PRELIMINARY INJUNCTION.

CONTRIBUTE $15/ACRE TO THE SGMA DEFENSE FUND

SGMA Update continued from page 1

Subsidence Enforcement Tiers

Every GSA is required to have a subsidence plan under SGMA. It must establish Measurable Objectives (MOs) and Minimum Thresholds (MT's) related to subsidence. Subsidence is defined as the change in groundwater levels per water year relative to the elevation of the land's surface in 2020 (the baseline year). Each GSA must also establish milestones to minimize subsidence by 2040. Restrictions will increase as the aquifer sinks in the areas experiencing subsidence:

- At 40 percent of the allowable maximum subsidence value, wells in high-risk areas must be metered and reported monthly.
- At 50 percent, pumping of recharge credits from the lower aquifer stops, and no new deep wells are allowed.
- At 75 percent, transitional pumping is suspended in the affected area.
- At 100 percent, wells linked to subsidence are shut down.

This staged system is designed to act before the State intervenes, demonstrating that groundwater can be managed locally.

Registration and Outreach Still Pending

Well registration with the GSA remains incomplete as they work to hire a firm to develop the online portal. Outreach efforts are underway to explain the GSP and its implications, and to prepare landowners for the upcoming Proposition 218 election, where they will have the opportunity to vote on funding the GSA.

South Fork Kings GSA

Allocation Policy Steps Down Through 2040

The Grower Advisory Committee advanced the allocation policy to version 14.5. Transitional pumping, which is a decreasing annual allotment aside from sustainable yield, will gradually decrease through 2040, allowing landowners time to adjust to the lower water allocation.

Tribal lands and community systems such as Stratford and the El Dorado mobile home park will be eligible for allocations if they register. Transfers outside the Tulare Lake Subbasin will not be permitted, and new caps are being drafted to limit the amount of water that can leave the GSA.

Subsidence Baseline and Clay Layer Concerns

Subsidence remains the main focus. South Fork Kings set 2020 as its baseline, aligning with other GSAs. Monitoring will utilize satellite data supplemented by local benchmarks. Members also noted that more than one clay layer is sinking, adding complexity to how subsidence is tracked.

Well Registration Makes Progress

Well registration is now at 67 percent. Moving forward, groundwater allocations will not be assigned without a properly registered well. This policy creates a clear incentive for landowners to complete the process.

Well Mitigation Pilot in Design

A pilot well mitigation program is being developed in partnership with Self-Help Enterprises. Seven wells have been identified as likely responsibilities of the GSA. The pilot will allow the agency to test costs and procedures before rolling out a broader program.

Budget and Fees on the Table

South Fork also turned to financial planning. A flat per-acre-foot pumping fee has been proposed, with legal costs expected to increase the total. Discussions are ongoing, and these values are subject to change. Both the budget and allocation plan will move to the Board together this fall. With neighboring GSAs under probation, South Fork is under pressure to demonstrate progress.

Tri-County Water Authority

Water Quality and PFAS Questions

Preparation of the annual report to the Department of Water Resources (DWR), due in April 2026, is currently underway to track both groundwater levels and water quality. Debate continues over whether all GSAs should test for PFAS and other compounds or if testing should be limited to high-risk areas. The outcome will determine both costs and compliance burdens.

Meter Policy Aligned with Neighbors

Tri-County updated its meter policy to align with other GSAs in the Tulare Lake Subbasin. Landowners will be required to sign access agreements to allow

SGMA Update continued on page 9

Sites Reservoir: California's Biggest Storage Project in Decades Moves Forward

In late August, Governor Gavin Newsom announced nearly $219 million in new state funding for the Sites Reservoir project, a proposed off-stream reservoir in the Sacramento Valley that could hold up to 1.5 million acre-feet of water. With this latest commitment, the project is now eligible for more than $1 billion in Proposition 1 funds, bringing it one step closer to construction.

A Reservoir for a Drier Future

Sites Reservoir would be built in a natural valley west of the Sacramento River. Unlike dams that block a river, Sites is designed as off-stream storage: water would be pumped in during wet years and stored for release during dry ones. At full capacity, it could store more than three times the volume of Millerton Lake.

The goal is to give the state more flexibility in managing water supplies during California's inevitable swings between flood and drought. State officials estimate the reservoir could provide enough water in dry years to supply millions of households, while also supporting environmental flows and water quality in the Delta.

What It Means for the San Joaquin Valley

For farmers in Kings County, the project won't deliver direct water allocations. But it matters. California's water system is interconnected, and additional storage in the Sacramento Valley can reduce stress on Delta pumping, improve operational flexibility, and potentially increase transfer opportunities for water users further south. In short, increased storage capacity up north can lead to greater reliability in the San Joaquin Valley.

Cost and Timeline

The project's estimated cost has climbed to nearly $6.8 billion. Federal funding is projected to be approximately $780 million, while state and local water agencies will cover the remaining costs. Construction could begin as early as 2026, with initial operations targeted for the early 2030s.

To expedite the process, Governor Newsom has certified the project for regulatory streamlining under SB 149, thereby limiting delays caused by CEQA lawsuits. "Each day that we delay these projects costs our state

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Rain Year continued from page 1

feet, as a sequence of atmospheric rivers replenished reservoirs and flooded river channels.

This type of variation emphasizes the difficulty of forecasting. While statewide climate trends often receive attention, local totals can differ significantly from year to year. The National Weather Service reports that El Niño conditions, present in early 2025, are waning, with neutral conditions expected to persist through winter. Historically, neutral years in the San Joaquin Valley are unpredictable. Some bring strong storms, while others stay dry. NOAA's current seasonal outlook indicates a slightly increased likelihood of above-average rainfall across Central California during winter and early spring, but confidence remains moderate.

The Old Farmer's Almanac, which bases its forecasts on long-term historical patterns and solar cycles, reflects the mixed signals. The 2025 national outlook indicates "pockets of a wild winter," with Northern California likely to experience wetter conditions, while Central and Southern California may see drier conditions. The Almanac has long been a trusted reference for generations of farmers and remains a popular supplement to agency forecasts.

For Kings County, the focus is not on certainty but on preparation. Rainfall, Sierra snowpack depth, and reservoir storage levels will be key indicators as the season goes on. Farm Bureau will closely monitor conditions and provide updates on the development of the water year.

Almanac Callout

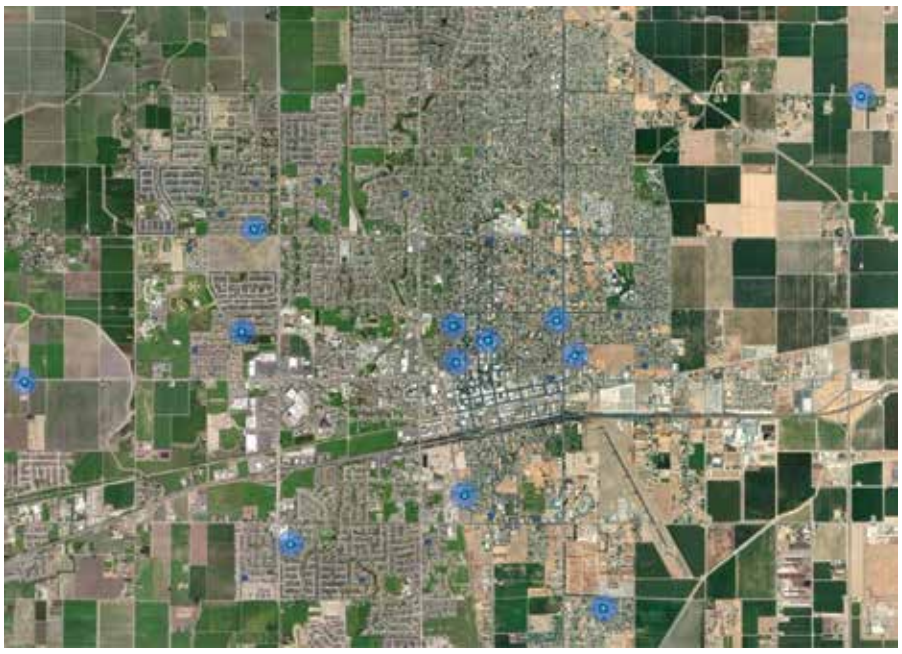
Old Farmer's Almanac 2025 Forecast

- Northern California: near-normal to wetter
- Central California: variable, leaning dry
- Southern California: below-normal precipitation

Ag Commissioner's Compliance Report

Jimmy Hook, Agricultural Commissioner/Sealer

Proclamation of an Emergency Program Against the Glassy-Winged Sharpshooter for the Area of Hanford in Kings County



Between July 9, 2025 and August 13, 2025 a total of nine Glassy-winged Sharpshooters (GWSS) were detected traps being serviced by the Kings County Department of Agriculture inspectors. Since then, an additional 27 GWSS were detected in the Hanford area.

Based on these detections and recommendations from California Department of Food and Agriculture GWSS staff entomologists, the CDFA concludes that an infestation of GWSS exists in the area. This pest presents a significant, clear, and imminent threat to the natural environment, agriculture, economy, and private and public property. Unless emergency action is taken during these GWSS' life cycles, there is high potential for sudden future detections in Kings County.

GWSS is a vector for the bacteria that causes Pierce's disease and the pest's ability to overwinter in the adult life stage, there is a high potential for sudden future detections of GWSS in Hanford. Therefore, CDFA is working with the Kings County Department of Agriculture to carry out emergency actions to prevent this loss and damage.

The GWSS is a dangerous, invasive, aggressive vector of Pierce's disease. Pierce's disease is considered one of the most devastating diseases of grapevines in the world. The bacterium that causes the disease, Xylella fastidiosa, kills grapevines within two to five years of infection. There is no cure for Pierce's disease. There are currently 111 properties of grape production within the county at risk from the recent GWSS detections. A total of 3,682 acres of grapes, valued at $39,339,000, was grown in Kings County in 2024.

In addition to grapevines, GWSS' hosts include over 360 genera of plants, which vary widely from woody plants to annual and perennial herbaceous plants. However, GWSS is known to prefer to overwinter in citrus and can be easily moved in bulk citrus. There is one citrus packing house and currently 141 sites of citrus production within Kings County. A total of 843 acres of citrus, valued at $7,901,500, was grown in Kings County in 2024.

The Kings County Department of Agriculture staff will implement an intergovernmental, coordinated state and community-wide plan to provide detection, delimitation and treatment of the GWSS in Kings County and suppress or eradicate any populations as rapidly as possible. Ensure the movement of products and commodities does not present a risk of moving GWSS to non-infested areas.

Traps have been deployed on the outer edges of the find areas to determine the extent of the infestation. The next step is to begin foliar and soil injection treatments on all properties within a 150 meter radius of each find site. Kings County Department of Agriculture will provide direction and oversight during the treatment phase which is expected to take up to two years. GWSS detection trapping will continue throughout the county. The photo shows the current find sites with a blue dot, and the surrounding blue shaded area shows a 150 meter radius.

For more information or any questions please contact the Kings County Department of Agriculture, (559) 852-2830 or agstaff@co.kings.ca.us.

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third-party inspections and permit monthly reporting. Non-compliance will default to using Land IQ data with a two percent penalty.

El Rico and Southwest Kings GSAs

Neither El Rico nor Southwest Kings held formal meetings this month.

Across the Subbasin

The State's draft Best Management Practices document sparked concern. Many worry it stretches beyond guidance and could be treated as enforceable. Some requirements, such as data on "critical head," are not yet available, creating further challenges.

The sustainable yield study is not yet complete, though most GSA's in the subbasin have agreed on common subsidies and thresholds. A new subsidence map is being finalized for review.

What You Can Do

- Attend and participate in your GSA Board meetings.
- Register your wells. Allocations will not be issued to unregistered parcels.
- Pay attention to fee discussions. Flat pumping fees are being incorporated into budgets, and a Prop 218 election will require every landowner's vote to approve per-acre assessments.
- Learn the new proposed subsidence triggers. Restrictions will be implemented in stages long before the thresholds are fully reached.
- Stay engaged. Outreach is just starting, and the more you follow now, the fewer surprises you will face later.

The Path Ahead

September drew sharper lines. The State may be slowed by the lawsuit, but local control is being tested in real time. Agencies are proving whether they can write and enforce the rules SGMA requires. For landowners, the path forward is clear: register wells, track use, follow the new rules, and stay present in the process. Every voice still matters, and every well truly does count.

Julie Martella is an independent consultant specializing in SGMA implementation, narrative strategy, and community trust building. She tracks groundwater policy across the Tulare Lake Subbasin.

KCFB
KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU
ANNUAL
MEETING

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 20, 2025

Tachi Palace Hotel & Casino
17225 Jersey Ave, Lemoore, CA 93245
6:00 pm Reception - 7:00 pm Dinner and Program

Join us for the Kings County Farm Bureau Annual Meeting as we look back on the year's achievements, celebrate our dedicated members, and enjoy an exciting live auction! We'll also honor outgoing President Shane Bickner for his service and welcome our new slate of officers.

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Sites Reservoir continued from page 8

more money," the Governor said when announcing the new funding.

The Debate Continues

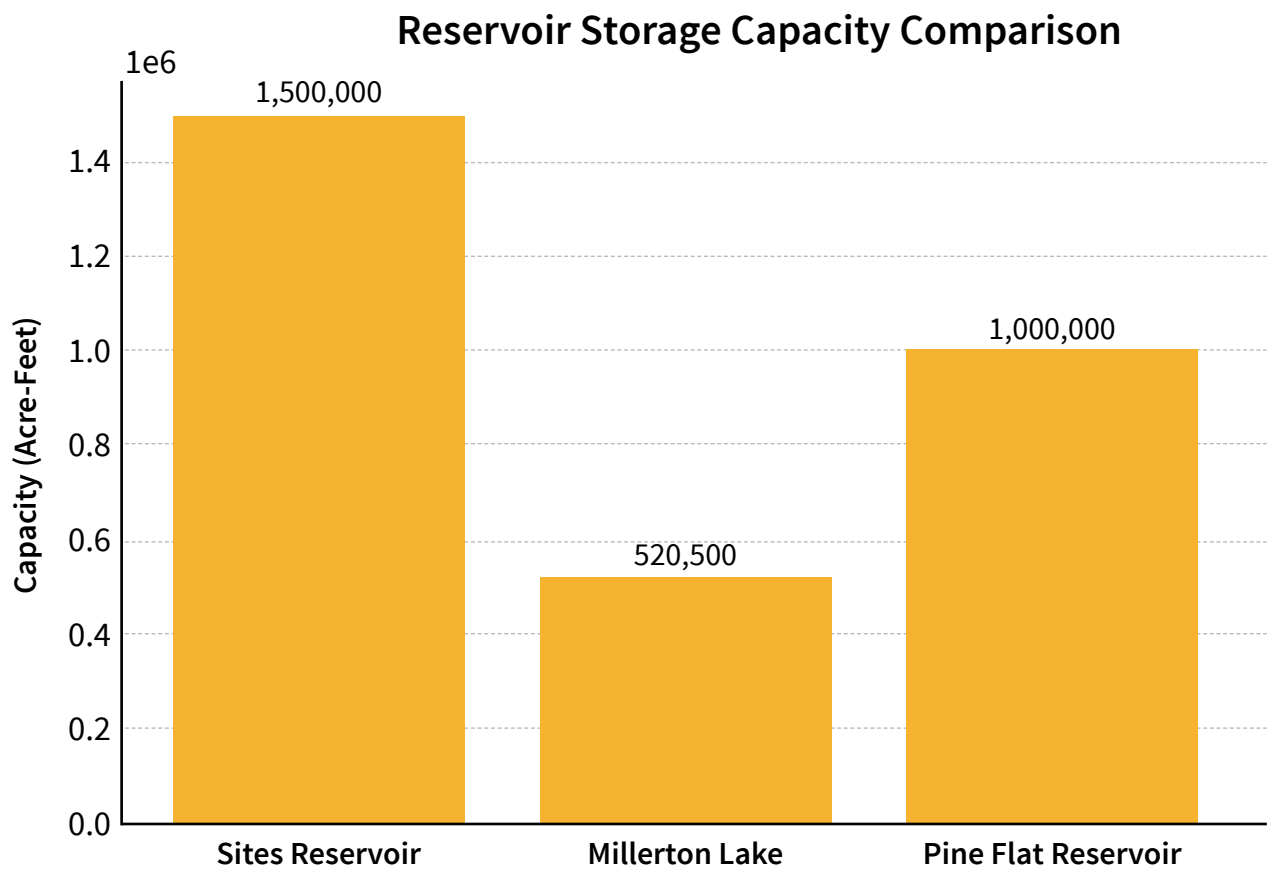
Supporters argue that Sites Reservoir is crucial for preparing for more prolonged, more severe droughts and ensuring California's food and water security. Critics warn the project could reduce river flows for salmon, harm ecosystems, and fall short of its promised water yields.

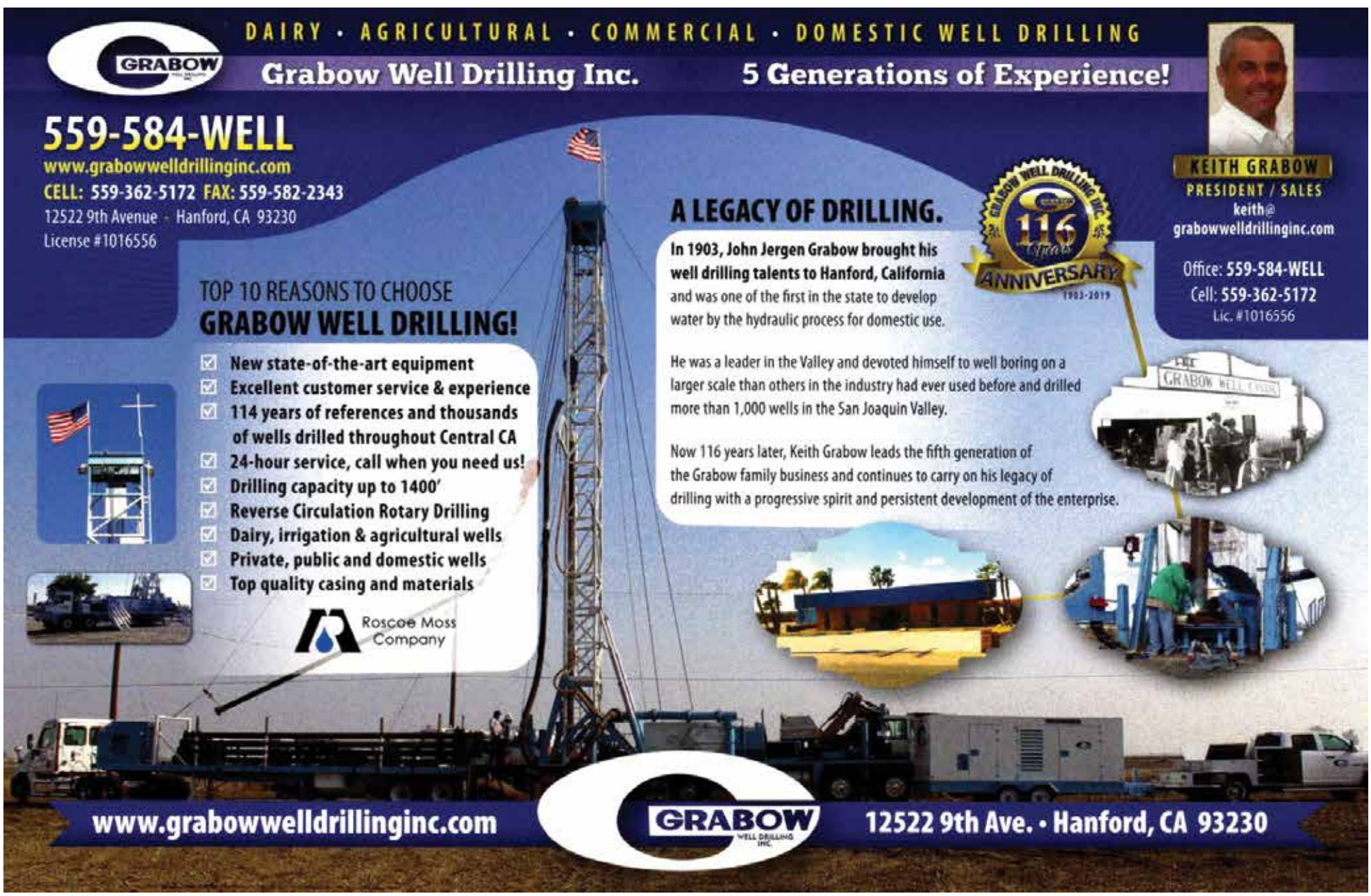
Despite the debate, Sites represents California's most significant attempt in decades to build large-scale water storage. For Valley agriculture, its progress will be a key test of whether the state can deliver the infrastructure needed to keep farms and communities resilient in the face of climate extremes.

Visuals

At 1.5 million acre-feet, Sites Reservoir would store more than three times the volume of Millerton Lake and nearly double Pine Flat Reservoir.

Planned location of the Sites Reservoir in the Sacramento Valley. Water would be diverted from the Sacramento River during high flows and stored off-stream for use in dry years.





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Kings County Rural Crime Report

Contributed by Detective Santos

In September, the Rural Crimes Unit made a second arrest regarding a burglary suspect from an agricultural business in the area of Highway 43 and Fargo Avenue. The subject was booked into the Kings County Jail with a $200,000 bail amount.

We received a call for service in the area of 10th Avenue and Tucson Avenue in Corcoran regarding a male subject cutting an enclosed fence surrounding a pump. We were able to identify the suspect due to footage from a game camera, which the property owner had concealed near his pump. There was no copper wire stolen, but the fence was damaged and valued at approximately $1000 to replace. The suspect was later located and arrested.

The Kings County Rural Crimes Unit works closely with the Tulare County AG Unit, as we share common suspects between both counties. We assisted Tulare County with multiple investigations into copper wire thefts from agricultural wells that have been occurring in their county. We were able to provide Tulare County with a common suspect, which we believe was involved with one copper wire theft in our County, but it was later determined the suspect was involved in nearly a dozen copper wire thefts in Tulare County. The information we shared with Tulare County was crucial and ultimately led to the arrest of the suspect. The following week, we assisted the Tulare County AG Unit in recovering stolen equipment from Tulare County, possibly in the Corcoran area. Once we confirmed the stolen property was located at a house in Corcoran, a search warrant was executed by Tulare County, and over 10 subjects, most of which had active warrants and were taken into custody. Firearms were also located at the residence along with drugs and drug paraphernalia. The equipment was recovered and turned over to Tulare County.

In the area of 25th Avenue and Utica Avenue in Kettleman City, a theft report was taken. There was approximately 350 feet of copper wire stolen from an oil pump, which was valued at approximately $10,000 to replace. We are currently attempting to identify the suspect.

In the area of 2nd Avenue and Houston Avenue, there was an attempted theft of a welder at a property that is currently vacant but being remodeled. The property owner has several cameras located on the property and provided us with video footage. The suspect was later identified, and we were able to locate the suspect living in Lemoore. The suspect was arrested and transported to the Kings County Jail.

This week, we received information regarding multiple subjects stealing items from a vacant property on 10th Avenue, just south of Iona Avenue. Once we arrived at the property, a black Ford F-150 took off at a high rate of speed. We attempted to conduct a traffic stop on this vehicle, but the driver did not yield, and a pursuit was initiated. The suspect was chased through multiple dirt roads but ultimately taken into custody on 7th Ave, just south of Highway 198. A shotgun was thrown by the suspect over the fence into a backyard, where the vehicle came to a stop. This driver was booked into the Kings County Jail on multiple charges, including weapons charges.

We continue to encourage victims of theft to install cameras on their property to assist us with our investigations. Cameras are one of the best tools we as law enforcement have, and based on the video footage this month alone, we made several arrests. There are multiple types of cameras and brands that can be purchased. We recommend buying hard-wired cameras when there is electricity available. If there is no electricity where you need to mount the cameras, battery-powered game cameras are a great option too. As far as game cameras are concerned, there are two different types that I am aware of. The first camera type records motion and saves the images onto an SD card, which must be reviewed manually. The second type, which we recommend buying, works off a cellular network.

Once there is motion with these cameras, the images are sent directly to your cell phone. At this time, if you determine this person should not be on your property, you can call the Kings County Sheriff's Office dispatch, and we will have a Deputy sent out to your property.

If you have any questions, feel free to call me or any of our unit members at any time.

Detective Santos (559) 904-6893
Detective Estrada (559) 212-7512
Investigator Ward (559) 280-5441

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2025 Special Election • Tuesday, November 4

The California Farm Bureau Federation Board of Directors adopted the following recommendation on Proposition 50, a statewide ballot measure that will go before California voters in a special election on Tuesday, Nov. 4.

PROPOSITION	POSITION
PROPOSITION 50 **REMOVES INDEPENDENT CITIZENS COMMISSION** Prop 50 dismantles the independent Citizens Redistricting Commission's work, handing congressional map-drawing power to politicians who have released plans to break up rural districts.	**OPPOSE** **REASONING:** Prop 50 will further concentrate political power in urban centers and leave agricultural communities without fair representation. **Prop 50 is a direct attack on fair maps and rural California.** Independent redistricting works, and voters trust the process. Farmers need representatives who understand agriculture. Join us and vote NO on Prop 50.

WHY VOTE NO?

- **Defend rural representation.** Ensure California's farming and ranching communities are fairly represented in Congress.
- **Protect independence.** Keep redistricting in the hands of a nonpartisan commission.
- **Prevent political games.** Stop politicians from drawing districts to benefit themselves.
- **Save taxpayer money.** Avoid wasting $250 million on a special election.

KEY DATES

- **Oct. 6, 2025** – Ballots mailed to voters
- **Nov. 4, 2025** – Special Election Day

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR FARMERS

California's independent redistricting process protects all of the state's constituents equally, including rural farming communities. It keeps farming regions whole instead of lumping them into distant urban districts. If Prop 50 passes, towns such as Alturas in Modoc County could be represented by a politician hundreds of miles away in Sausalito who may share little in common. Voting NO ensures rural constituents can elect leaders who understand issues such as water resources, land use and food production.

WHAT CAN YOU DO?

- **Join the coalition:** Submit your endorsement at **cfbf.com/prop50**
  County Farm Bureaus and individual members are encouraged to sign on.
- **Spread the word:** Share "No on Prop 50" messages in your newsletters, meetings and social media.
- **Stay informed:** Watch for Ag Alert commentaries, FarmTeam alerts and Farm Bureau podcasts with campaign updates.
- **Vote NO on—or before—Tuesday, Nov. 4.** Protect rural representation and keep maps independent.

www.cfbf.com/prop50

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